

Department of Mechanical Engineering
B.Tech Project Presentation on

VOLLEY: Controlled CubeSat Deployment from a Hosted Orbital Platform

Completed Gen5 system-level computational evaluation



Presented By

Adityavardhan Mishra · Pratham Chawla

PRN 23070125054 · PRN 23070125029

Guide: Vikas Gulia

Final review: 10 October 2026

SYMBIOSIS INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY PUNE

Presentation route

OUTLINE

01 Introduction

02 Literature review

03 Research gap

04 Objectives

05 Research methodology

06 Timeline

07 Work progress

08 Results

09 Conclusion

10 Future work

11 References

Which missions might value orbital choice?

INTRODUCTION

Repeat fleets

Configurable smallsat families and replenishment exist. That context does not establish demand for VOLLEY.

Delivery buyer

A carrier, rideshare integrator or fleet operator might need several distinct release states from one host.

Gen5 test

Compare commanded release with springs, host manoeuvres, transport and onboard propulsion on the same mission.

No customer is confirmed; modeled Gen5 3U mass fails its preset criterion.

Existing methods solve different parts of the problem

LITERATURE REVIEW

Approach	Strength	Limit for this thesis
Spring deployer	Flight heritage; compact; simple	Limited tailored release speed
Spring release / drag	Relative state or drag can create phasing	Timing alone, with no relative state change, cannot
Orbital transfer vehicle	Larger orbit changes	Greater bus, mass and integration burden
Electromagnetic research	Commandable acceleration studied	Armature, high-g or maturity constraints vary

A narrower, testable contribution

RESEARCH GAP

Commanded release for an unmodified CubeSat at moderate acceleration, with the full system counted.

Contribution examined

Gen5 reusable-sled linear motor, 3U payload, magazine, pulse power, arrest and orbital utility.

Boundary

Electromagnetic CubeSat deployment exists in prior work. Payload qualification and physical performance remain unproved.

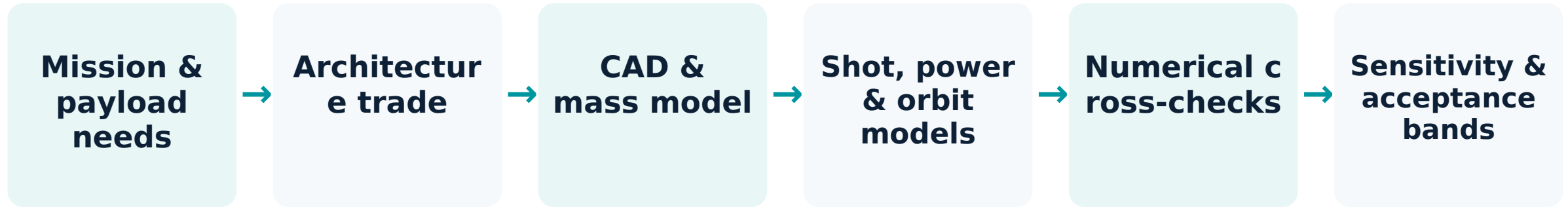
The analytical research objectives have outcomes

OBJECTIVES

Research objective	Final thesis outcome
Design a commandable 3U system	Gen5 CAD and complete subsystem architecture documented
Calculate shot and control performance	Rated shot, power and dispersion models completed
Evaluate orbital utility	Predicted energy and lifetime benefit for stated cases
Count full installed burden	Mass rollup completed; 3U parity criterion failed
Test credibility of key claims	Numerical cross-checks and limits recorded

A completed analysis chain from mission to decision

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY



Models were challenged and revised; hardware performance remains outside this thesis's evidence.

Numerical checks strengthened the final baseline

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Question	Method / cross-check	Evidence limit
Field and thrust	Analytic winding; magpylib; FEM	No measured thrust constant
Shot and power	Dynamics; Monte Carlo; ngspice	Assumed components and interfaces
Structure and flow	CAD; CalculiX; OpenFOAM	No payload qualification
Orbital change	Orbit model; Cowell / GMAT cases	Lifetime depends on atmosphere

Project evolution: documented decisions and analysis

TIMELINE

2023

Hosted concept Free-flyer concept reframed around a host platform

Mid-2025*

LSM direction Coilgun study gives way to a linear synchronous motor

2025-26*

CAD generations Geometry and mass models mature through Gen5

Jul-Sep 2026

Gen5 evidence Cross-checks, defect corrections and thesis record

Oct 2026

Final review Gen5 results, failed criterion and thesis record presented

* Approximate historical milestone; not a documented semester deadline.

2026 findings were incorporated in the final baseline

TIMELINE

Jul

CAD-derived sled mass replaced an optimistic parametric estimate

Aug

Depth-resolved thrust calculation lowered the rated speed

Aug

Enclosure buildup exposed the full 3U mass penalty

2026

Independent orbit checks rejected a solar-invariance claim

Final

Results and failures retained in the submitted thesis record

The current review package is assembled and traceable

WORK PROGRESS

Design delivered

Gen5 CAD, magazine and release architecture, subsystem models and system mass rollup.

Analysis delivered

Shot, control, circuit, structure, thermal, orbit and alternative-case results.

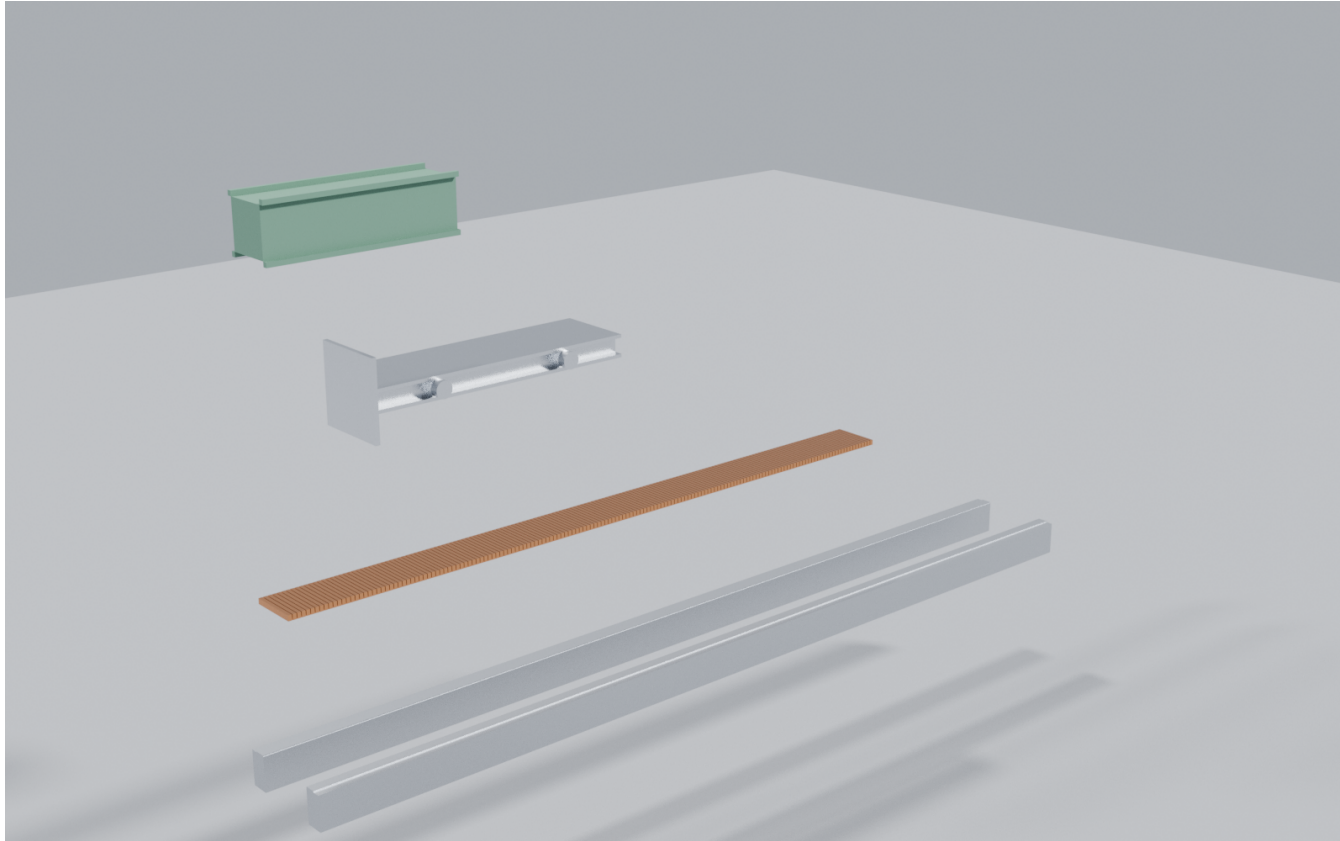
Evidence delivered

Manuscript, figures, scripts, numerical checks, provenance and defect register.

Scope: fixed computational study with failed design gates; no physical qualification claim.

Gen5: fixed reference geometry, feeder fit still open

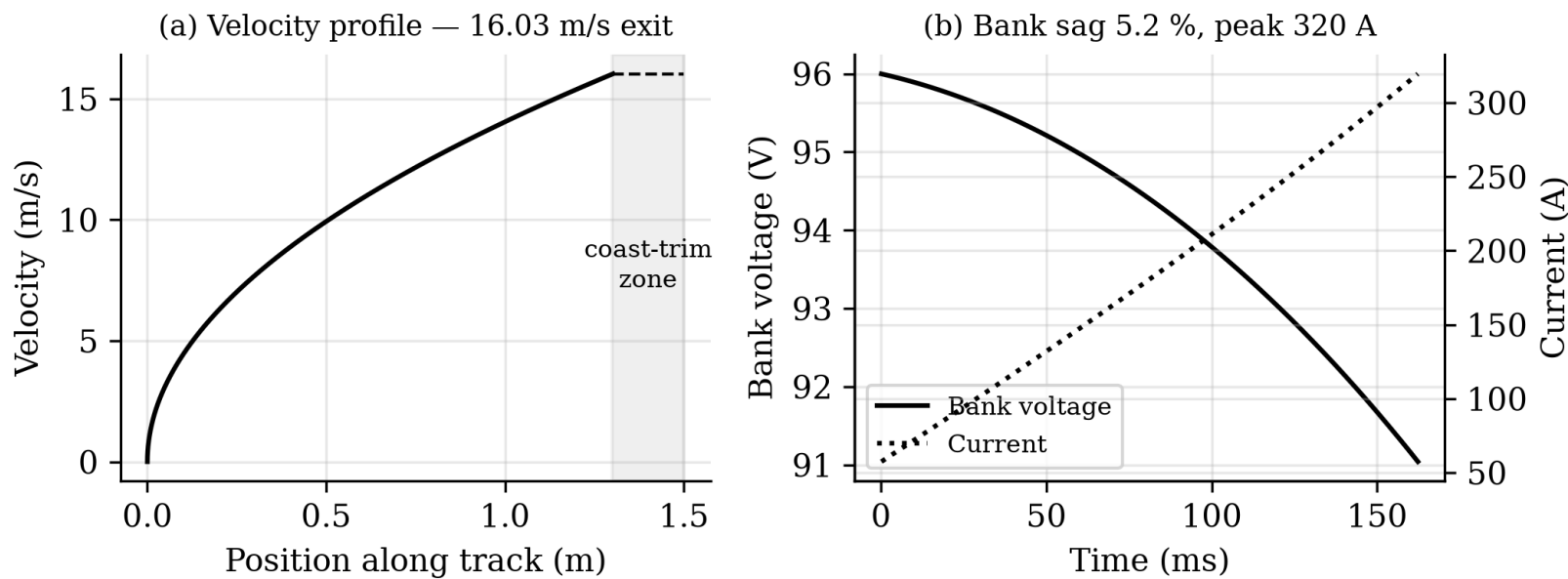
RESULTS



- 1.5 m linear-motor track and double-sided Halbach arrays
- Reusable 9.45 kg magnet sled
- Two cassettes; twelve 3U satellites
- FreeCAD STEP assembly: side-fed placement clashes

Rated 3U shot: performance predicted by the model

RESULTS



16.0 m/s
exit speed

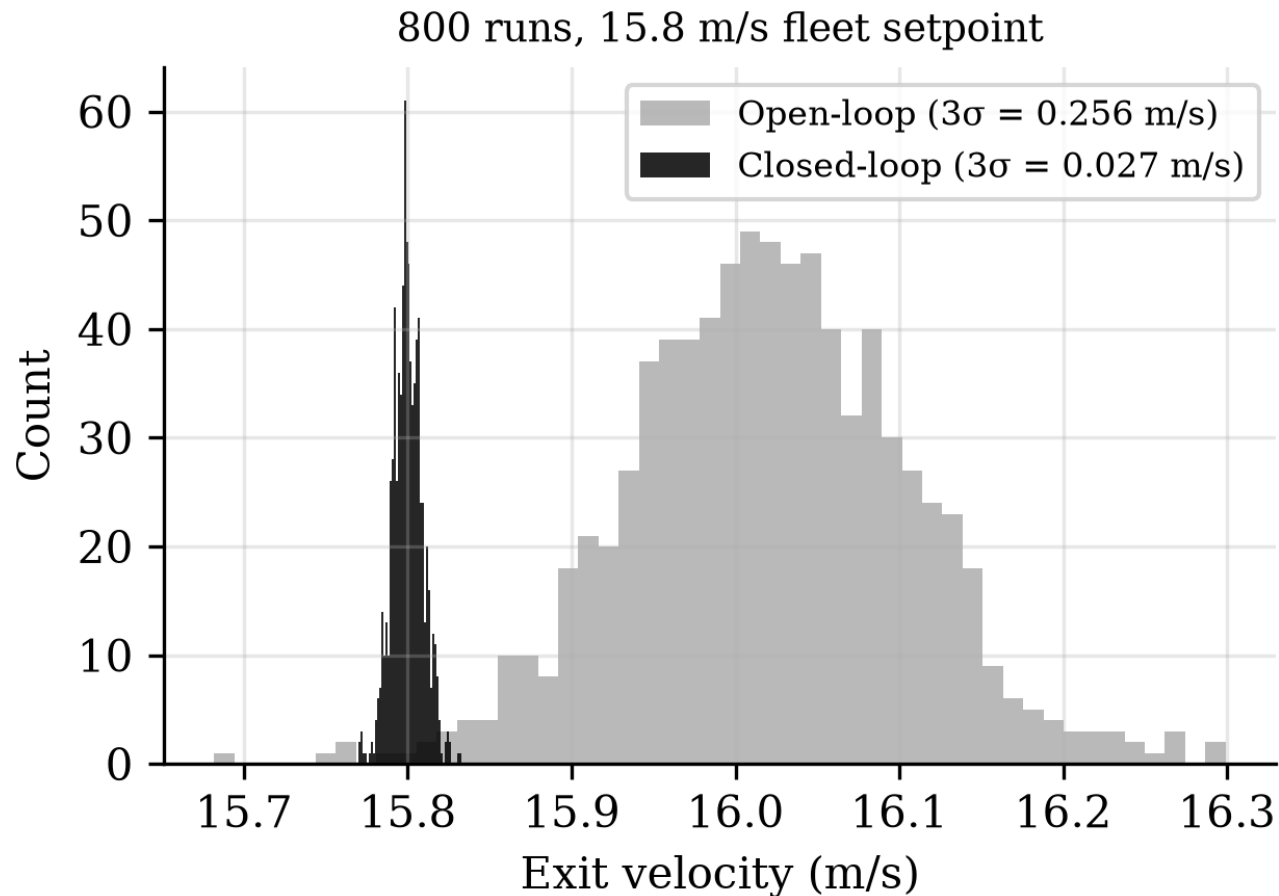
10.07 g
acceleration

2.782 kJ
gross draw

18.8%
net efficiency

Modelled command precision is narrow; it is unmeasured

RESULTS



0.0274 m/s

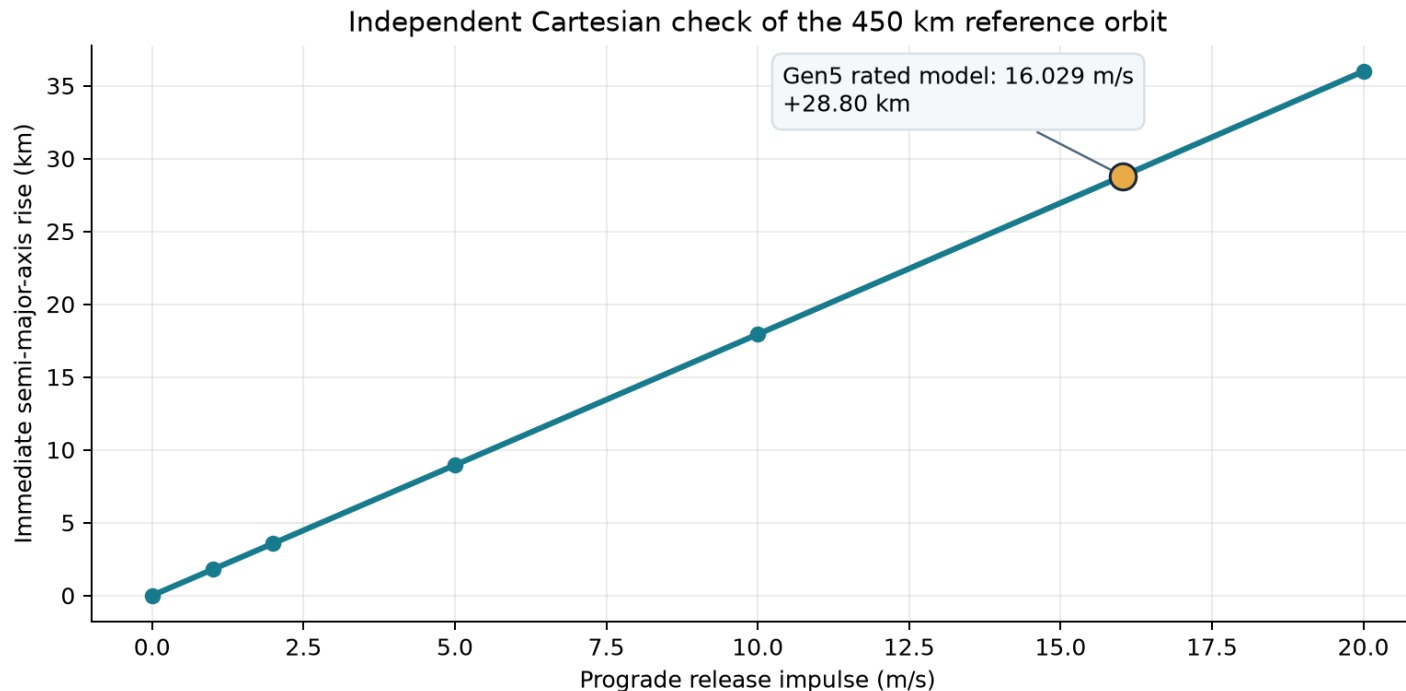
3σ exit-velocity dispersion at a 15.8 m/s fleet setpoint.

Evidence limit

Monte Carlo under modelled sensing and plant tolerances; no measured dispersion.

Rated orbit geometry now has a separate numerical check

RESULTS



+28.8008 km

Immediate two-body axis rise
at the rated 16.029 m/s input.

1.60× open

Lifetime remains
atmosphere-dependent without a
current rated independent rerun.

Persistent phasing requires a relative state change; this result concerns orbital energy.

Gen5 fails its 3U mass comparison

RESULTS

Modeled dry mass, 12 slots **126.6 kg**

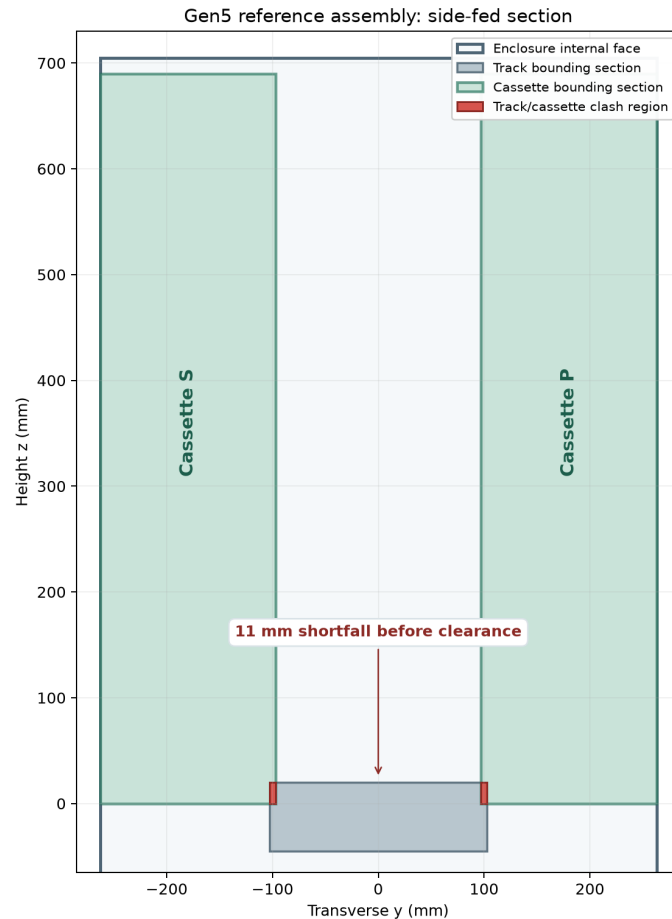
Gen5 per 3U  **10.55 kg**

Spring comparator  **~6 kg**

1.76× heavier per 3U payload; the preset 15% parity band fails.

The current side-fed assembly fails a geometric fit check

RESULTS



Reference placement only: a new feeder or enclosure would need a new configuration and rerun.

11 mm short

537 mm of track and cassette width inside
526 mm of usable enclosure width.

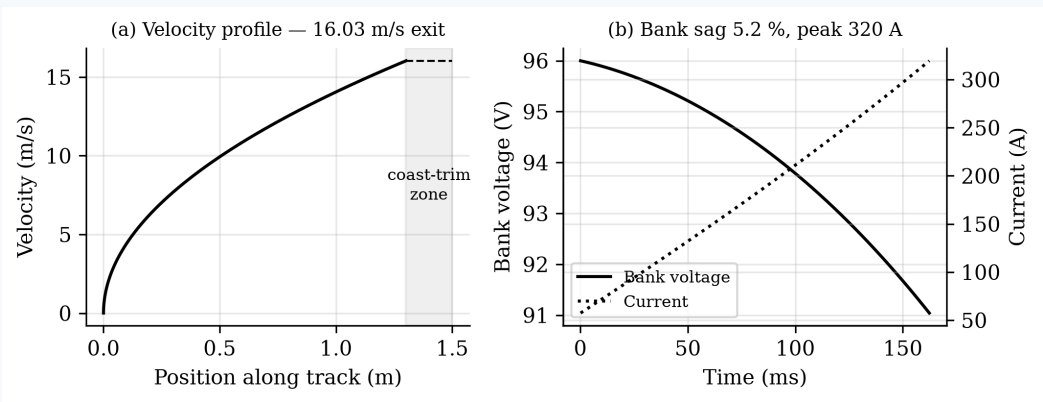
32,915 mm³

Exact track/cassette clash on each side;
CadQuery and FreeCAD agree.

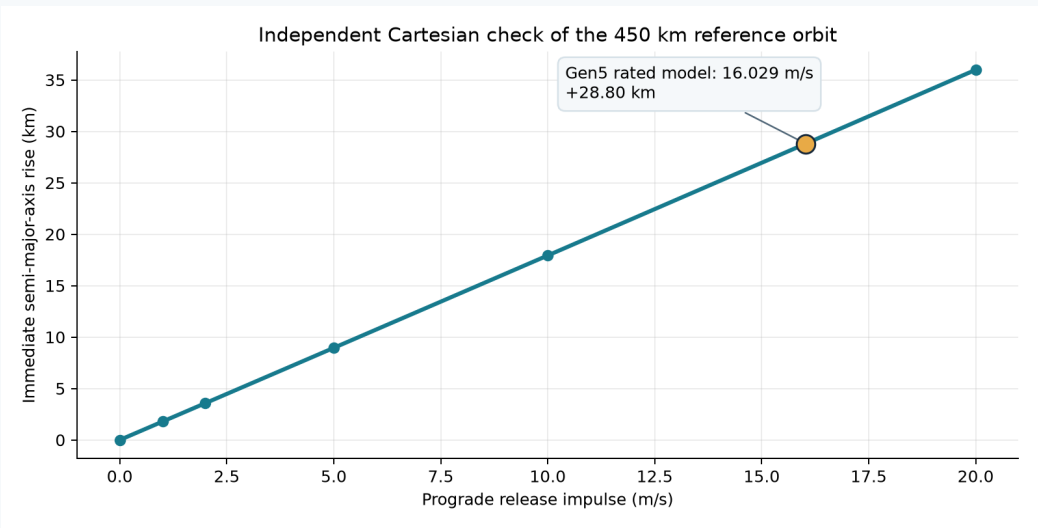
Computational demonstration: from shot to orbit

RESULTS

1. Simulate a 3U shot → 16.0 m/s



2. Model the orbital response



**Compare predicted orbital change and full installed mass with the spring baseline.
Simulation, not physical demonstration.**

The research question has a completed answer

CONCLUSION

- The Gen5 system-level model predicts 16.0 m/s 3U release and a conditional orbital benefit.
- The model is 76% heavier per 3U customer and the side-fed CAD reference also clashes.
- Independent numerical checks corrected the baseline and defined the limits of its claims.
- Conclusion: the analytical objective is complete; Gen5 does not pass the 3U selection criterion.

Gen6 reopens the mechanism and installed-system trade

FUTURE WORK

One shared path • sequential feed • commanded release for each CubeSat

- Investigate approximately 1–2 m/s through 1 km/s across mission cases.
- Compare electromagnetic, stored-energy, gas/fluid, hybrid, BOLLEY and conventional options.
- Count feeder, retention, arrest, control, energy, thermal, host loads and shared faults.

1 km/s is a research target, not demonstrated speed or payload/provider compatibility.

Next milestone: one reviewable first-test configuration

FUTURE WORK

Freeze

Named mission, payload and host surrogate

Decide

Fair mechanism and installed-burden trade

Measure

Field, contact, release, arrest, loads and cycle behavior

Review

Drawings, BOM, procedures, uncertainty and review decision

Core literature and standards (1/2)

REFERENCES

- [1] JAXA, JEM Payload Accommodation Handbook, Vol. 8: Small Satellite Deployment ICD.
- [2] Cal Poly, CubeSat Design Specification, Rev. 14, 2020.
- [3] C. Foster et al., 'Constellation phasing with differential drag on Planet Labs satellites,' J. Spacecraft Rockets 55(2), 2018.
- [4] H. Feng et al., 'Design and reachable domain analysis of on-orbit electromagnetic launcher for CubeSats,' Int. J. Aerospace Eng., 2025.
- [5] Y. Zhao et al., 'Design and analysis of a new deployer for the in-orbit release of multiple stacked CubeSats,' Remote Sensing 14(17), 4205, 2022.

Methods and project records (2/2)

REFERENCES

- [6] Y. Zhao et al., ‘Simulation analysis and experimental verification of the transport characteristics of a high-volume CubeSat storage device,’ *Aerospace* 12(6), 466, 2025.
- [7] K. Halbach, ‘Design of permanent multipole magnets with oriented rare earth cobalt material,’ *Nucl. Instrum. Methods* 169, 1980.
- [8] NASA, General Environmental Verification Standard (GEVS), GSFC-STD-7000A, 2013.
- [9] D. A. Vallado, *Fundamentals of Astrodynamics and Applications*, 4th ed., 2013.
- [10] A. Mishra, VOLLEY-thesis: manuscript, baseline, provenance and validation records, repo head b30ffdc, 28 Sep 2026.
- [11] VOLLEY/BOLLEY, Current Plan and Status — PLAN-R2, controlled working baseline, 29 Sep 2026 (project plan).